

board as “contractors” who could employ whomever they wanted, but were also in charge of their own protection. More than 2.2 million cubic metres of material, including rock, was moved during the construction. Building material would be brought in either by motor lorries or, where there were only bridle paths, donkeys. While dynamite was brought in easily, the more unstable gunpowder for blasting shale came in tongas (horse-drawn carriages) from Peshawar. Pipes were laid for proper water supply and fortified towers built to protect the camps from feuding or raiding parties. The unpredictable weather was yet another challenge to overcome. To top it all, some locals would occasionally fire shots at engineers from vantage points.

Despite the challenges, the first section from Jamrud to Landi Kotal opened on 3 November 1925 and the final section to Landi Khana on 3 April 1926. *The Times* in a report from 3 November 1925, recounted a declaration by the railway member of the Governor-General’s Council, Sir Charles Innes, that “the railway would stir men’s imagination far beyond the limits of British India”.



▲ A viaduct on the Khyber Pass Railway connects the towns of Landi Kotal and Landi Khana (in modern-day Pakistan).

“Impossible and forbidden, but, all the same, inevitable!”